

STEPS TO FREEDOM

I kept my head down. Read when I could.

Eventually I got released early for good behaviour.

It was a cracker of a day when I walked out.

Cold, obviously. Invercargill wasn't suddenly going to stop being Invercargill just because I'd got out of prison.

Stace was there waiting for me.

I didn't have much. Whatever personal property I'd had when I was taken into custody, the bits and pieces that had made their way into my cell, and a cheque for two hundred and eighty dollars.

Steps to Freedom.

That was genuinely what it was called.

If you'd been locked up for six months or more, the New Zealand Government apparently decided two hundred and eighty bucks was enough to launch you successfully back into society.

Which was nice of them.

We walked into town and cashed it.

Then we went home.

Or, more accurately, we went to Lynn's.

Lynn was Stace's mum. I'd met her before, but only a couple of times, and now I was moving into her house directly from prison, so there was probably room for things to be slightly awkward.

It was a small state house down a long shared driveway in a quiet cul-de-sac. Nothing particularly remarkable about it except that Lynn kept the place immaculate. Stace and I had the bedroom off the kitchen.

I put my stuff down.

That was moving day taken care of.

I knew Melissa well already. We got on easily and she'd become more like family than just Stace's sister. Nakita I barely knew; not surprisingly, given how young she was, we hadn't spent much time around each other.

Lynn welcomed me in properly, although there was some awkwardness underneath it. I couldn't tell whether she actually wanted me living there

or whether she wanted Stace there badly enough that I came as part of the package.

Probably a bit of both.

Stace and Melissa hadn't lived with their mother since they were infants. If Stace wasn't staying there, there was a reasonable chance Melissa wouldn't either.

So there I was.

Fresh out of prison, living with Stace in her mother's spare bedroom while everyone worked out exactly what this new arrangement was supposed to look like.

I had people to see, plenty of whom didn't know I was out yet.

I used part of the \$280 to buy half an ounce of buds.

Just weed.

Given some of the other shit that turns up later, that clarification is probably worth making.

Stace and I kept enough for ourselves and I moved the rest on. By the time it was gone, I had the original money back and about another hundy on top.

Not a bad return on the Government's reintegration package.

After that we went around to an old mate's place. It was one of those houses where somebody was always coming or going, the door was rarely shut for long, and news travelled considerably faster than anybody involved.

If you wanted people to know you were back, you didn't need to make phone calls.

You just went there.

By that evening, word was getting around.

We headed back to Lynn's because she was cooking roast lamb shoulder.

And Lynn's roast lamb was fucking sensational.

It was one of those meals you looked forward to when you knew it was on. Proper roast lamb, vegetables, the whole lot, done the way she did it.

The fact that I had spent six months eating prison food certainly didn't hurt.

During the rounds that afternoon someone had given me a bottle of homemade moonshine as a welcome-home present, so that came out as well.

Lynn barely drank.

The rest of us were somewhat more committed to the exercise.

There was still a bit of unease around the table at first. Lynn and I barely knew each other, and within a few hours of getting out I was already living under her roof with Stace.

There probably isn't a completely natural small-talk transition for that.

Fortunately, awkwardness and homemade moonshine have a fairly predictable relationship.

By the end of the night, most of it had disappeared.

Between the roast, the moonshine and being back beside Stace, things had started to feel almost normal.

The only complication was that Lynn's house was quiet.

Really quiet.

The sort of place where everybody could hear everybody else doing practically anything.

We were young, I'd just got out, and Stace had spent six months waiting for me. Apparently discretion wasn't going to be part of the reunion.

Our bedroom was off the kitchen. Lynn was only a few metres away.

Stace did not seem remotely troubled by either fact.

That became fairly obvious on the first night.

The moonshine might have taken care of the tension for the evening.

Morning brought some of it back.

Nobody mentioned the night before, but there was enough of it hanging around to suggest the moonshine had probably been helping more than any of us realised.

It didn't last particularly long because everyone had their own shit to do, and I had to report to parole.

At first that meant going in every morning. My parole officer was an older Māori bloke and a fucken good cunt. He wasn't interested in making the process any more complicated than it needed to be. If I turned up on time and wasn't obviously drunk or stoned, there wasn't much reason for either of us to spend all morning staring at each other. Some days I'd stick my head through the door so he knew I was there, and be back outside again a few minutes later.

That suited me fine. I'd get parole out of the way, then carry on with whatever I had lined up for the day. I was still making money the way I knew how, but I wasn't interested in adding burglaries, stolen cars or any of the other reckless shit that gave the cops any reason to come looking.

Living at Lynn's settled into its own rhythm as well. I was conscious that I'd arrived with almost nothing and moved straight into somebody else's house, so once I had a bit of money behind me I gave Lynn a few hundred dollars.

I don't remember her asking me for board. I just didn't like the idea of eating her food, using her power and sleeping under her roof while contributing nothing.

Around the same time I started putting things on lay-by at Farmers. Decent cookware, towels, blankets, crockery, all the boring household stuff that becomes fairly important once you realise you don't actually own any of it.

Stace didn't know.

That was intentional.

We'd lived together before I went inside, and Lynn's was somewhere we'd landed rather than somewhere I expected us to stay forever. I didn't know when we'd manage to get another place, but I wanted to start putting things aside for when we did.

So for a while that became the routine. Parole in the morning, whatever I needed to do during the day, back to Lynn's afterwards, and every so often another payment toward a collection of household shit for a home we hadn't found yet.

I came home one morning through the back door and found Shane sitting in the kitchen with Lynn.

That was unexpected.

More importantly, judging by Lynn's face, I wasn't supposed to know he was there.

Shane was Nakita's father and Lynn's on-again, off-again partner. He and I already had history, most of it stemming from an earlier incident involving Lynn that had given nineteen-year-old me what I considered a perfectly legitimate reason to get into a scrap.

Protective instinct was part of it.

So was the fact I liked fighting more than I probably should have.

Either way, we weren't mates.

Lynn looked caught.

Shane looked determined not to.

For a second the three of us just stood there in the kitchen pretending there was nothing remotely unsettling about any of it.

"Morning."

What the fuck is he doing here?

I walked through to the bedroom.

Stace was still asleep, so I told her when she woke up. Melissa found out later.

As far as they knew, Lynn had agreed Shane wouldn't be around.

Apparently that arrangement had become negotiable.

For the first little while his visits were kept quiet. Then the effort slowly disappeared. He came around more often, everybody knew, and within a couple of weeks there wasn't much point pretending anymore.

Shane was just back.

To his credit, Shane made a genuine effort to keep the peace with me. Offered me a sesh. Tried making small talk.

I wasn't a fan of small talk even with people I liked.

But it was Lynn's house. As long as he left her and the girls alone, I was prepared to leave him alone too.

One of the lads I'd known inside was already out and had a solid LSD connection in Dunedin.

He fronted me a thousand tabs.

The deal was simple enough. I had about a month to pay for them. If I wanted another thousand after that, next time I needed to bring enough cash to pay for half upfront.

Now, a thousand tabs was a lot of acid for Invercargill.

Not because I couldn't sell them.

I could.

That was actually the problem.

I knew I was the only one around with that sort of supply.

Well any supply at all it turns out, start moving too many too quickly and it wasn't going to take long before it became fairly obvious who had them.

So I sold them, just not enough to make myself red hot doing it.

By then New Year was only a couple of weeks away, and I asked Lynn if she minded us having a few people around at the house.

Nothing huge.

Me and Stace, Lynn and Melissa, Si, Steven and his mate Sam, and yea I included Shane.

Lynn was fine with it, so I started getting things together. Steaks, sausages, charcoal for the Weber, moonshine, some chairs in the shed and a stereo for music.

Pretty basic, really.

Food, booze, a few people we knew and somewhere to see in the New Year.

Si was one of the first there. He'd walked over from his mum's place, about forty-five minutes away, which wasn't particularly unusual for Si.

Steven and Sam turned up around mid-morning. Sam was Steven's best mate, but he was also Stace and Melissa's cousin, so there wasn't really anyone arriving who felt like they'd been invited into somebody else's gathering.

Once people started turning up, all the organising I'd done beforehand pretty much became irrelevant. The Weber was going, there was meat to cook, the stereo was on and we had chairs set up in the shed. From there the day just sort of found its own pace.

Steven and Sam were allowed to have a few drinks, although we made them eat first.

The weed didn't receive quite the same level of supervision.

Lynn drifted in and out of the shed throughout the day. Nakita was around too, but being the youngest by a decent margin she spent most of her time inside while the rest of us carried on.

And that was really all there was to it for a while.

People we knew, sitting around Lynn's place on New Year's Eve. Eating, drinking, smoking, music going in the background and absolutely no reason to think the night needed to be anything more complicated than that.

Then sometime after lunch, Shane arrived.

With his father.

His father was already fairly intoxicated.

Nobody had invited him.

Nobody particularly wanted him there.

There had been strong allegations circulating over the years about him having inappropriate involvement with underage girls.

No charges had been laid.

I didn't know whether the allegations were true.

What I did know was that Si and I were both aware of them, neither of us liked the man, and his presence immediately changed the atmosphere.

Lynn looked shocked to see him.

She tried to hide it.

I didn't bother.

I made it clear he wasn't welcome.

That was quickly explained away. He wasn't staying, apparently. Just dropping Shane off, having a quick drink, then heading off again.

Fine.

He didn't leave.

By around eight that evening, Shane's father was heavily intoxicated. It was still light outside.

Shane and Lynn were moving in and out of the shed when his father made a pass at Melissa. She didn't make a scene. She ignored him, shifted her chair further away and tried to carry on, but I saw the movement and knew something was wrong.

I asked if she was all good, loudly enough that everybody heard. She didn't really answer. She got up instead and moved across to stand with the boys and talk with Stace.

The next time Shane came into the shed, I told him to get his old man moving before he did something stupid and got hurt. Shane waved it away, then leaned over and said something quietly to his father.

He assured me the old man would leave when he finished his drink.

About half an hour later, the old man stood up and walked out toward the garden to take a piss. I thought that was it.

Then he came back, opened his cooler and helped himself to another drink. With all the fucking cheek in the world, he sat down beside Melissa and put his hand on her knee.

"Oi!"

I knocked the beer from his hand. The bottle smashed on the concrete and I had him by the scruff of his shirt before he could properly react.

"Fuck off while you've still got the chance to walk."

I threw him out of the shed. He landed on his hands and knees, scraping and cutting them on the concrete.

The commotion brought Shane back. He came toward me, but Steven and Sam stepped in before it went any further.

They knew me. They knew that when it came to somebody I considered family, volatile was probably the generous description. Add a good quantity of moonshine and things needed to be brought under control quickly.

I told the younger boys to sit down. Sam did. Steven stayed long enough to tell Shane what his father had done and convince him to get the old man out of there.

For a moment, that worked. Shane followed his father up the driveway, the old man got into his vehicle and left, and it looked like the whole thing might be over.

Then Shane came back.

“He’s just a harmless old man.”

Apparently the way his father had been put out mattered more to him than the reason for it.

At that age, once I decided violence had become necessary, I didn’t wait for the other person to throw the first punch.

Shane and I went toe to toe. The neighbour came outside. Lynn came out. Si tried to get between us before either of us did serious damage, then Shane caught him with a stray punch.

Wrong bloke. Wrong moment.

Si was in it now too.

The girls were screaming and Lynn was shouting that she had called the police. Stace understood what that meant immediately. An arrest for me didn’t just mean an arrest. I was on parole.

Shane broke away and ran up the driveway just as the first police car turned in. The officers knew both him and the address from earlier domestic incidents.

They treated him as the aggressor.

Which, depending on which thirty seconds of the evening you were assessing, wasn’t entirely wrong.

When he resisted, a second unit arrived.

Lynn disappeared back inside. I made myself scarce. The police took Shane and left.

It was New Year’s Eve, and they had plenty more calls waiting.

We didn’t see Lynn again for the rest of the night.

The music went back on. The drinks came out again. Whatever was left on the barbecue got eaten. The fight hadn’t ended the gathering, but it had changed the house.

Lynn knew her phone call had resulted in Shane being arrested, and it seemed to sit badly with her. From where most of us stood, the arrest wasn’t the only issue. Melissa was her daughter. Someone should have protected her before I ever needed to intervene.

Lynn would probably have seen it differently. So would Shane.

Afterward, she became distant and Shane disappeared for a while. Stace and Melissa weren’t particularly surprised by their mother withdrawing. From what I had seen—and from how the girls understood their

relationship with her—Lynn had never been consistently present for them in the same way she had been for Nakita.

After about a week, the open hostility subsided. Nothing had been resolved. People had simply stopped saying it out loud.

Parole, by comparison, had remained one of the least complicated parts of being out.

Then he retired.

And everything went to shit.

Her name was Sarah. Or maybe Sharon. I honestly can't remember, which tells you how much I wanted to forget those meetings.

She was young. Late twenties. Fresh out of whatever degree you need to become a parole officer. By the book in a way that wasn't cruel—just relentless.

This is the policy and I will follow it to the letter.

Somehow worse than cruelty. You can't argue with policy.